Somewhat stunned, Faf and I left the group and headed towards the nets in the corner of the cricket field. We reckoned we would hang around there and throw a ball at each other; no such luck.

'I said go away,' Mr Lindsay shouted across the field at us. 'That means go away. If you don't want to practise seriously, you are wasting your time and you're wasting my time, so please disappear.'

The lesson was learned.

Faf was our star player at school, selected for the 1st XI when he was only 14 years old. I joined him in the school team midway through the following season, when we were both 15, and we played together in the Affies side for the better part of four years, generally winning ... and completing most practices.

As ever in cricket, the statistics don't lie.

We won 20 out of 29 matches in 1999 and, in 2000, won 23 out of 25 matches, losing only to Grey College when we were destroyed by the bowling of Ryan McLaren, who would later play for South Africa.

Our standards slipped slightly in 2001, when we won 21 of our 24 matches, losing three out of four matches early in the season, including a painful defeat to Boys' High and further losses against St Alban's and to St John's from Johannesburg. I suffered a minor slump in batting form early in the season, and might have been dropped if I had not been keeping wicket, scoring 578 runs in total; Faf scored 751 runs.

I missed a large part of our final season at school, in 2002, recovering from the dislocated elbow suffered on the rugby field, but returned to the team and scored 425 runs in nine matches, including 113 against Tygerberg. Faf again played brilliantly, leading by example and scoring 994 runs at an average of 58.

We had won 21 out of 23 matches, losing to St Alban's and drawing with Maritzburg College, when we prepared to play our last two matches of the season: at home to Pretoria Boys' High and then away at King